

Are Theist Arguments More Often Slogan-Like?

Testing Rhetorical Overclaiming, Epistemic Compression, and Non-Falsifiability Risk

Report date: September 1, 2026 | Relevant debate assessments: 169 | Scored moves: 3,502

Hypothesis tested

The theist side will contain more rhetorical, non-falsifiable slogans than the non-theist side because faith is often reinforced through emotionally settling affirmations rather than publicly testable argument.

28.6% theist moves meeting the strict slogan-risk rule	7.9% non-theist moves meeting the same rule
3.62x pooled theist-to-non-theist relative rate	20.6 points mean within-debate difference (95% interval 16.3 to 25.0)

Verdict: the data strongly support the operationalized claim that theist-side moves more often function like slogans by combining weak public warrant, substantially overstated force, and compressed or unstable qualification. The data only provisionally support literal non-falsifiability, and they do not directly prove that emotional enforcement caused the pattern.

This report separates those three levels - measured pattern, philosophical interpretation, and psychological cause - so a strong result is not inflated into a stronger conclusion than the corpus can bear.

Prepared from the locked SLUGFESTER assessment ledgers and corrected position taxonomy.

1. Technical summary

Direct result

The strict slogan-risk proxy flags 398 of 1393 theist moves (28.6%) and 111 of 1407 non-theist moves (7.9%). The pooled relative rate is 3.62x.

- **Magnitude:** the pooled difference is 20.7 percentage points. The mean paired difference inside debates is 20.6 points.
- **Uncertainty:** the 95% whole-debate bootstrap interval runs from 16.3 to 25.0 points. The hypothesis direction appears in 103 debates, with 26 ties and 17 reversals.
- **Robustness:** the result persists in constructives, replies, load-bearing moves, equal-speaker weighting, and after removing the most frequent speaker on each side.
- **Boundary:** the result establishes slogan-like overclaiming. Literal slogan form, strict non-falsifiability, and emotional enforcement require direct coding not present in the locked rubric.

Strict slogan-risk share by side

2,800 scored moves in 146 debates; bars start at zero

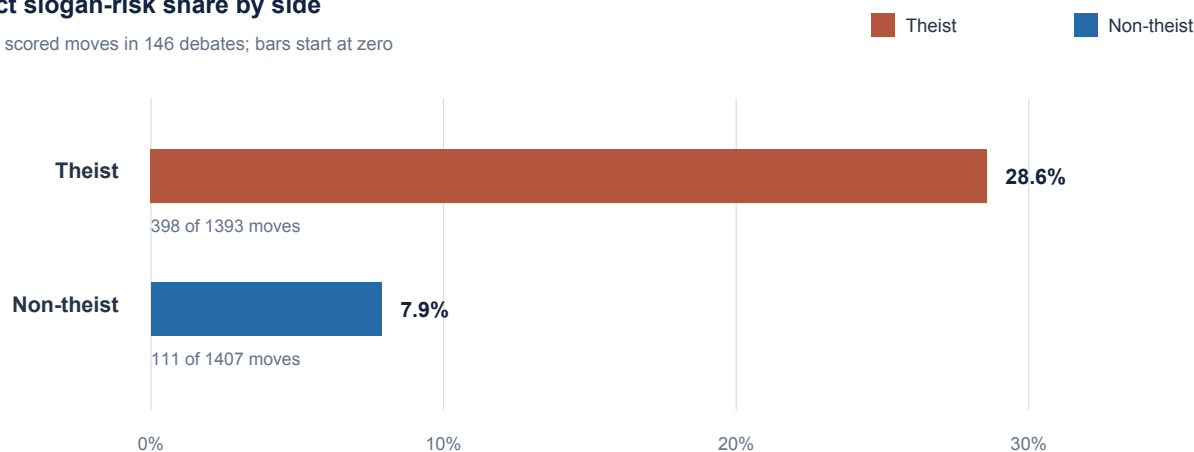


Figure 1. The primary three-part intersection uses identical thresholds on both sides. A move must be weakly warranted, materially overstated, and imprecisely compressed to count.

2. What counts as slogan-like argument

A slogan is not merely a short sentence. In debate, a slogan functions as a compact conclusion that carries emotional or identity-laden certainty while omitting the evidential and inferential work needed to expose the claim to correction. A concise argument can be excellent, and a long speech can be sloganistic. Word count is therefore a poor primary measure.

The analysis instead uses three locked dimensions that describe argumentative function. Evidence/warrant below 70 means assertion, anecdote, authority, selective examples, or speculation carries substantial weight. Material or radical overstatement means the claim's stated strength substantially exceeds that support. A compression defect means terms or scope are unstable or a needed qualification is missing or misleading.

Component	Locked rule	Argumentative meaning
Low warrant	Evidence/warrant below 70	The claim lacks enough public support or rival comparison
High force	Materially or radically overstated	The conclusion is presented more strongly than the support permits
Compression	Unstable term/scope or missing qualification	Language suppresses a boundary needed to test or interpret the claim
Strict slogan risk	All three conditions together	A compressed high-force conclusion does work its warrant has not earned

Why the definition is conservative

A move with poor evidence alone is not labeled slogan-like. A move with bold language alone is not labeled slogan-like. A move with an imprecise term alone is not labeled slogan-like. The flag requires the conjunction of weak support, excess force, and compression.

This makes the result harder to obtain and easier to interpret. It also avoids building religious vocabulary into the measure. The rule does not search for God, faith, revelation, hope, love, naturalism, science, or atheism. It reads the evaluator's closed judgments about support, force, and precision before applying the side label.

3. Every component is elevated on the theist side

Theist moves are more often weakly warranted (57.2% versus 19.7%), materially or radically overstated (36.3% versus 10.0%), and compressed or unstable (53.4% versus 29.9%). Missing qualification alone appears in 19.9% versus 7.7%.

The strict intersection is therefore not a statistical artifact produced by one permissive threshold. Each component points in the same direction, and requiring all three still leaves a 20.7-point difference. The result describes a recurring epistemic configuration: the claim is not sufficiently established, is stated at a force the evidence does not support, and lacks a stable boundary that would make correction easier.

Component diagnostics and strict intersection

Share of moves in the 146-debate closed-findings cohort

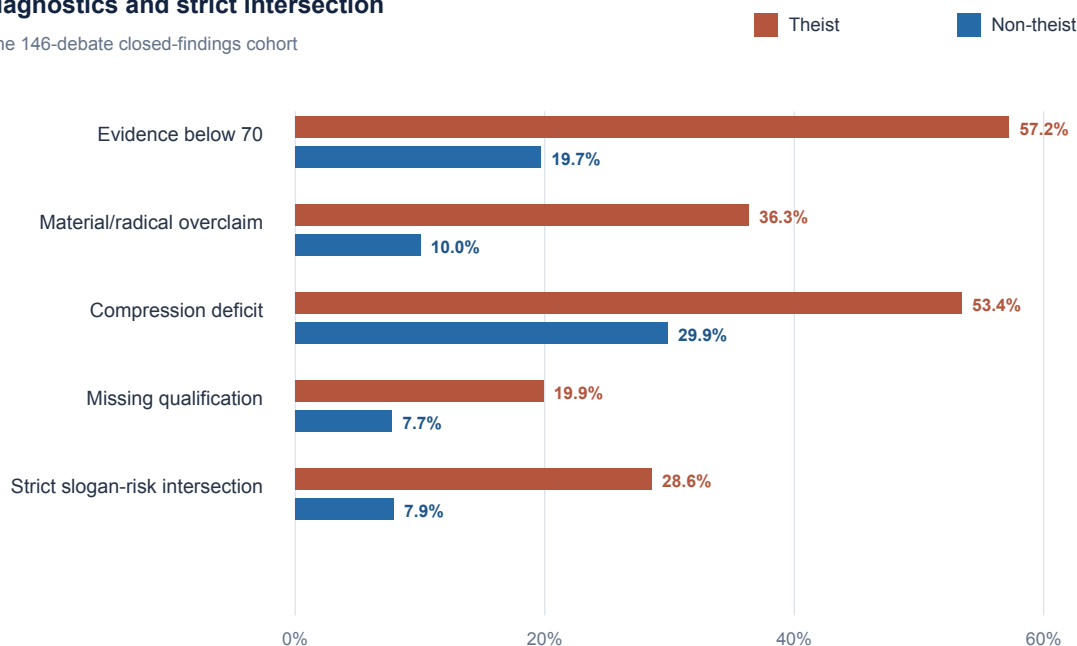


Figure 2. Component shares and their strict intersection. All bars begin at zero and use the same 2,800-move denominator cohort.

Diagnostic	Theist	Non-theist	Difference
Evidence below 70	57.2%	19.7%	37.5 pp
Material/radical overclaim	36.3%	10.0%	26.3 pp
Compression deficit	53.4%	29.9%	23.6 pp
Missing qualification	19.9%	7.7%	12.1 pp
Strict slogan risk	28.6%	7.9%	20.7 pp

4. The result is paired within debates

Pooled move rates are easy to understand but moves are nested inside debates. The main uncertainty check therefore gives each debate one paired difference: its theist slogan-risk share minus its non-theist slogan-risk share. The analysis then resamples whole debates rather than pretending 2,800 moves are independent observations.

Paired result

The mean within-debate difference is 20.6 percentage points. Its 95% whole-debate bootstrap interval is 16.3 to 25.0 points.

Within-debate outcome	Debates	Share
Theist side has higher slogan risk	103	70.5%
Equal rate	26	17.8%
Non-theist side has higher slogan risk	17	11.6%

The existence of 17 reversals matters. It shows that the metric is not a disguised side label and prevents the report from treating all theists as one kind of reasoner. The finding is a distributional tendency: theist-side moves meet the strict rule much more often across the corpus, while particular debates and speakers can depart from that pattern.

The interval describes uncertainty across the observed debates, not a probability that the hypothesis is metaphysically true. The curated sample and repeated participants still limit generalization to all public debate. What the interval does establish is that the observed difference is not driven by a small handful of debate rows.

5. Burden, role, and speaker checks

The theist side usually argues the affirmative, which could create a generic burden disadvantage. Frequent speakers could also dominate pooled move counts. The robustness analysis therefore repeats the same strict rule within constructives, replies, load-bearing moves, the role-reversal subset, and after removing William Lane Craig and Matt Dillahunty, the most frequent speaker on each side.

Whole-debate robustness intervals

Theist minus non-theist slogan-risk rate, percentage points; 95% clustered intervals

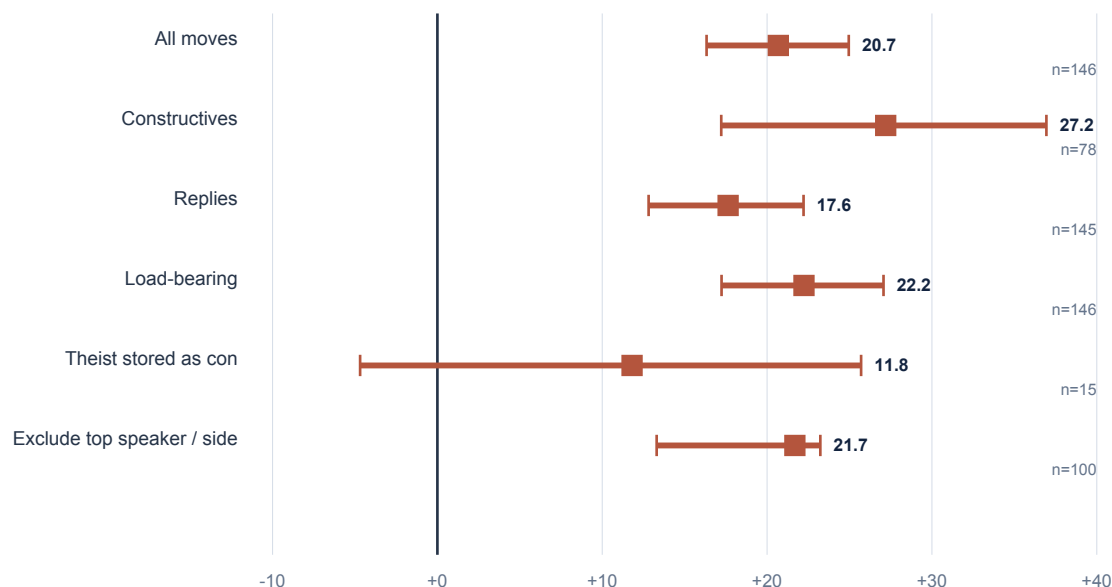


Figure 3. Each square is the mean whole-debate difference; horizontal lines are 95% clustered bootstrap intervals. The role-reversal interval crosses zero because only 15 closed-findings debates qualify.

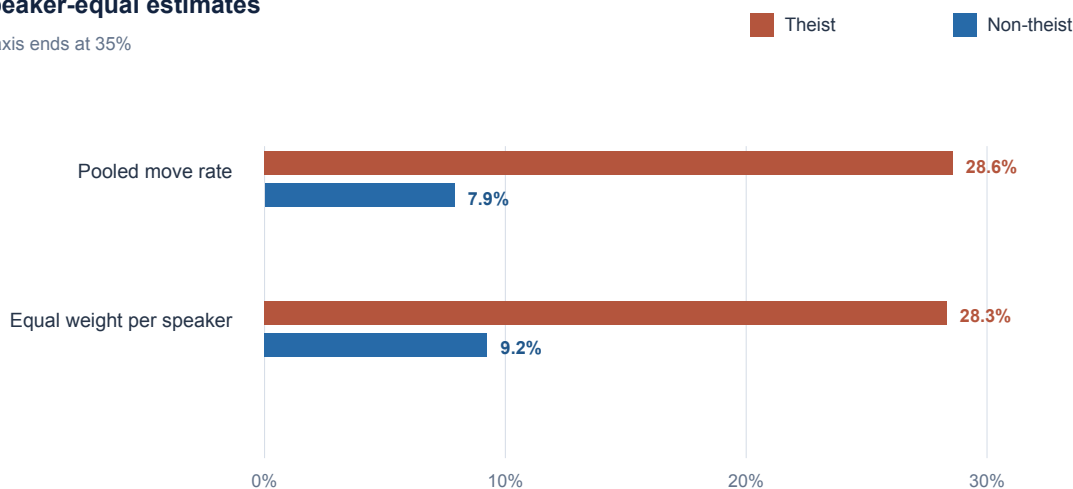
Check	Difference (pp)	95% interval	Debates
All closed-findings moves	20.7	16.3 to 25.0	146
Constructive moves	27.2	17.2 to 36.9	78
Replies	17.6	12.8 to 22.2	145
Load-bearing moves	22.2	17.2 to 27.1	146
Debates with theist side stored as con	11.8	-4.7 to 25.7	15
Excluding the most frequent speaker on each side	21.7	13.3 to 23.2	100

6. Frequent speakers do not create the result

The non-theist side is actually more concentrated in a smaller number of recurring speakers: 44 non-theist-side speakers versus 78 theist-side speakers in the primary cohort. To prevent either group's prolific participants from receiving disproportionate influence, the analysis computes each speaker's personal flag rate and then gives every speaker equal weight.

Pooled and speaker-equal estimates

Bars begin at zero; axis ends at 35%



Speaker-equal means: 78 theist-side speakers and 44 non-theist-side speakers.

Figure 4. Pooled move rates and equal-speaker means tell the same story. Equal weighting yields 28.3% for theist-side speakers and 9.2% for non-theist-side speakers.

Weighting	Theist	Non-theist	Difference
Pooled moves	28.6%	7.9%	20.7 pp
Each speaker equal	28.3%	9.2%	19.1 pp
Median speaker	24.3%	4.0%	20.2 pp

Removing the most frequent speaker on each side also preserves a large difference. This does not eliminate every speaker effect; it shows that the headline is not simply a William Lane Craig versus Matt Dillahunty comparison. A mixed-effects model in a future human-coded study would be the stronger next step.

7. Fallacy and bias tags corroborate the pattern

Published move tags provide an independent-looking but incomplete layer. Fifty-nine relevant debates contain at least one published fallacy or bias tag, covering 1,412 moves split almost perfectly between sides. In this cohort, 23.5% of theist moves and 7.4% of non-theist moves receive any tag.

The narrower epistemic-insulation cluster includes argument from ignorance, special pleading, subjective validation, confirmation bias, and belief bias. These tags capture routes by which a preferred conclusion can be protected from rival explanations, contrary outcomes, or independent testing. The cluster appears in 8.2% of theist moves and 1.0% of non-theist moves.

Published fallacy and bias tag rates

Secondary cohort: 1,412 moves in 59 relevant tag-bearing debates

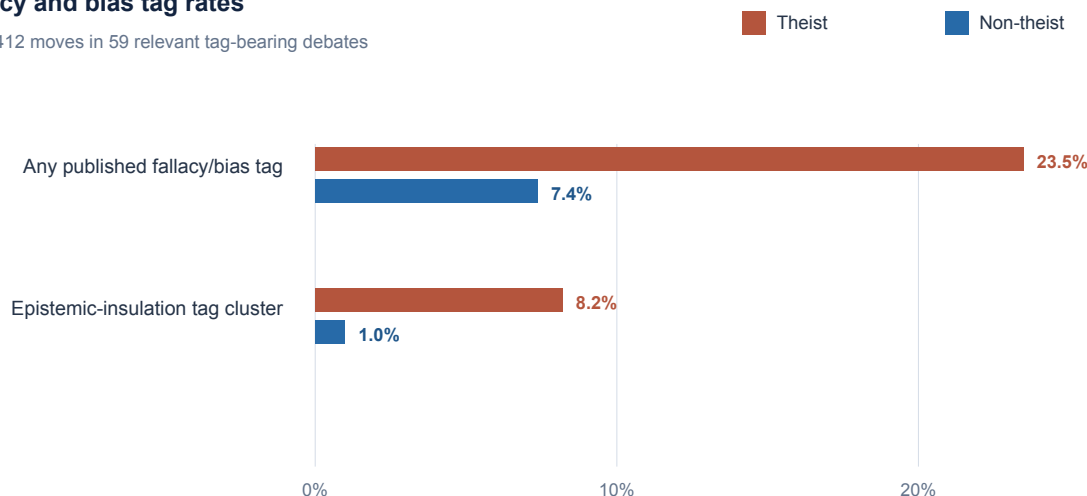


Figure 5. Tag rates in the partial tag-bearing cohort. The denominator is moves, so a move with multiple tags still counts once within each displayed category.

Why this remains secondary

Tag coverage is not corpus-complete and may reflect when detailed annotations were added to the publication pipeline. The paired direction is strong, but these tags corroborate the primary closed-field result rather than replace it.

8. Examples of unfalsifiable slogan proffering

The complete count comes from the mechanical rule, not from selected examples. Here, **unfalsifiable slogan proffering** means offering a rhetorically settled conclusion without stating a clear observation or argumentative result that would count against it. John Lennox supplies several concrete cases: 15 of his 56 closed-field moves meet the strict rule. Each card below identifies both the slogan function and the missing route to disconfirmation.

Miracle rejection becomes a prior-bias diagnosis

Debate 169 | John Lennox | Evidence 54 | materially-overstated

Claim: Miracles are special divine actions within a universe of regularities, and their categorical rejection reflects an antecedent exclusion of the supernatural.

Slogan function: Miracles are affirmed as special divine actions while categorical rejection is attributed to an antecedent exclusion of the supernatural, turning an evidential objection into a diagnosis of the critic's framework.

Falsifiability problem: No public criterion distinguishes a genuine special divine action from mistake, legend, or anomaly; categorical nonacceptance can be explained as prior prejudice rather than allowed to reflect evidential failure.

Createdness becomes an affirmation of infinite worth

Debate 170 | John Lennox | Evidence 61 | materially-overstated

Claim: A human person has infinite value and profound meaning because that person bears the creator's image and exists because God wanted that person to be.

Slogan function: Infinite value and profound meaning are asserted directly from bearing God's image and being wanted by God, giving the metaphysical affirmation emotional force without independent public support.

Falsifiability problem: God's wanting a person and the person's image-bearing are not connected to an observable condition that could count against the claim; every person's existence is defined as compatible with it.

Postmortem compensation absorbs present suffering

Debate 170 | John Lennox | Evidence 64 | materially-overstated

Claim: Christian hope can transcend suffering because God can compensate victims after death, Christ entered suffering, and eternal life without pain is better than extinction.

Slogan function: Christian hope is presented as transcending suffering because God can compensate victims after death, Christ shared suffering, and eternal life can outweigh extinction.

Falsifiability problem: No earthly amount or distribution of suffering can defeat the response if any harm can be compensated after death, while the proposed compensation lies outside ordinary observation.

Personal manifestation becomes public proof

Debate 142 | Ray Comfort | Evidence 39 | radically-overstated

Claim: The resurrection is warranted by personal manifestation of the living Christ, promised to those who repent, trust Christ as sin-bearer, and follow him.

Slogan function: A private experience is offered as warrant for resurrection and made available only through repentance and commitment, leaving no independent success criterion for an outsider.

Falsifiability problem: No publicly observable result is specified that would distinguish a genuine manifestation from expectation, suggestion, or error; access to the confirming experience is conditioned on prior repentance and trust.

Disagreement is converted into confirmation

Debate 142 | Ray Comfort | Evidence 30 | radically-overstated

Claim: Rejection of God reflects a preference for avoiding exposure and moral accountability under divine law, analogous to wrongdoers avoiding law enforcement.

Slogan function: Unbelief is explained as moral avoidance, so rejection of the claim is absorbed as evidence of the claimant's diagnosis rather than treated as possible counterevidence.

Falsifiability problem: Denial does not count against the claim: it is reclassified as confirmation that the denier wishes to evade divine accountability.

Unknown reasons protect the preferred conclusion

Debate 128 | William Lane Craig | Evidence 57 | materially-overstated

Claim: Observed suffering does not defeat God unless it is probable that God lacks morally sufficient reasons and that a better feasible world was available.

Slogan function: A speculative salvation-maximizing reason is used to shift the burden while no comparative evidence establishes that such a world is probable or feasible.

Falsifiability problem: Any observed suffering can remain compatible with theism by positing an inaccessible morally sufficient reason, while no suffering threshold or distribution is named that would lower confidence.

Unanswered questions license revelation

Debate 53 | Dinesh D'Souza | Evidence 66 | materially-overstated

Claim: Revelation is needed because reason cannot answer ultimate questions such as purpose, life after death, and cosmic justice, so faith is not unreasonable when addressing matters beyond reason's limits.

Slogan function: Reason's inability to settle ultimate questions is treated as support for revelation without an independent test of revelation's reliability.

Falsifiability problem: The move supplies no independent condition under which a purported revelation would fail, nor a test that discriminates among incompatible revelations claiming to answer the same questions.

Explanatory difficulty becomes affirmation

Debate 59 | Michel-Yves Bollere | Evidence 50 | materially-overstated

Claim: The unresolved emergence of life from nonliving matter and the immense informational complexity attributed to cellular DNA provide additional evidence of extraordinary fine-tuning.

Slogan function: Unresolved origin-of-life questions and an unsupported complexity comparison are used as positive evidence for extraordinary fine-tuning without a discriminating rival comparison.

Falsifiability problem: Present explanatory difficulty is treated as confirmation, but no possible natural account or evidential outcome is stated that would count against the fine-tuning inference.

9. Counterexamples keep the claim honest

The pattern is not uniquely theist, and good theist arguments are common enough to matter. The same strict rule flags non-theist moves when scientific confidence becomes antireligious dismissal, when simplicity claims rely on undefined probability measures, or when naturalistic possibilities are treated as established explanations.

Science-versus-religion slogan

Debate 85 | Peter Atkins | Evidence 40 | radically-overstated

Claim: Scientific practice and religious belief are intellectually incompatible because science distinguishes fact and evidence from the superstition and wishful thinking on which religion relies.

Slogan function: Religion is compressed into superstition and wishful thinking, and categorical incompatibility is asserted beyond the supplied comparison.

Falsifiability problem: The categorical wording supplies no boundary case or religious practice that could qualify the claimed incompatibility.

Unbounded simplicity claim

Debate 14 | Richard Carrier | Evidence 46 | radically-overstated

Claim: A random selection from unrestricted possibilities overwhelmingly favors a vast godless multiverse, while an omniscient and omnipotent God has maximal specified complexity.

Slogan function: An unrestricted possibility space is said to overwhelmingly favor a godless multiverse without a justified probability measure.

Falsifiability problem: Without a defined measure over the unrestricted possibilities, no observation is connected to a specified probability shift that could defeat the asserted overwhelming preference.

High-quality theist counterexamples

The following theist-side moves do not meet the slogan-risk rule. They show explicit evidence, disciplined modal scope, or careful comparative method. Their presence is important: the result is a frequency difference in argumentative practice, not an assertion that theism prevents rigorous reasoning.

Cumulative manuscript and contextual evidence

Debate 137 | William Lane Craig | Evidence 88 | matched

Claim: First Corinthians 15:3-11 is authentic rather than interpolated because all manuscripts contain it, early writers cite it, its vocabulary and pronouns fit the context, and its removal damages Paul's argument.

Slogan function: A theist-side counterexample that is well warranted, calibrated, and precisely qualified.

Falsifiability problem: None identified in this selected counterexample; the move states evidence, comparison, or modal limits that expose it to correction.

Explicit Bayesian comparison

Debate 139 | Matthew Adelstein | Evidence 87 | matched

Claim: Hypotheses should be assessed by both their prior probability and how much more strongly the observed evidence is predicted by them than by alternatives.

Slogan function: A theist-side counterexample that is well warranted, calibrated, and precisely qualified.

Falsifiability problem: None identified in this selected counterexample; the move states evidence, comparison, or modal limits that expose it to correction.

Careful modal qualification

Debate 144 | Alvin Plantinga | Evidence 86 | matched

Claim: To establish compatibility between theism and Darwinism, it is enough to identify a possible supplementary proposition joining them; doing so does not assert that divine intervention actually occurred.

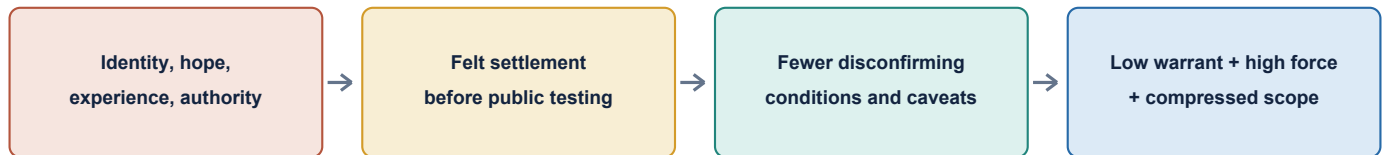
Slogan function: A theist-side counterexample that is well warranted, calibrated, and precisely qualified.

Falsifiability problem: None identified in this selected counterexample; the move states evidence, comparison, or modal limits that expose it to correction.

10. Emotional affirmation as the proposed mechanism

The user's causal proposal is that theism is often maintained through emotional devices such as affirmation rather than through rationally discriminating argument. The observed data are consistent with that mechanism. Personal manifestation, hope, identity, moralized descriptions of unbelief, inherited authority, and theological fit can make a conclusion feel settled from inside a tradition before the public evidential burden has been met.

The proposed emotional-affirmation mechanism



Only the final box is directly measured by the primary proxy; the preceding links are the causal interpretation to be tested.

Figure 6. The proposed causal chain. The strict proxy directly measures the final epistemic configuration. The emotional and social links remain interpretive hypotheses.

A rational argument exposes itself to loss: it states what evidence bears on the claim, compares live alternatives, limits its force, and identifies conditions under which revision would be appropriate. Affirmation works differently. It rehearses the conclusion, binds it to identity or value, interprets doubt as a personal or moral failure, and makes contrary outcomes compatible with the original commitment. When this structure enters debate, the predictable trace is exactly the one measured here: low warrant, high asserted force, and compressed qualification.

Causal boundary

The ledgers do not observe emotion, persuasion, social enforcement, or private conviction. Emotional affirmation is therefore a plausible explanation of the measured configuration, not an experimentally established cause.

11. Rival explanations

Rival	Prediction	Assessment
Affirmative burden	Theist sides must build more cases from scratch	Constructive and reply differences remain large; load-bearing moves show a 22.2-point difference
A few frequent speakers	Prolific apologists or skeptics dominate the count	Equal-speaker weighting is 28.3% versus 9.2%; excluding the top speaker on each side preserves the result
Role storage	The public pro/con orientation creates the result	The role-reversal direction remains positive, but only 15 debates qualify and its interval crosses zero
Evaluator preference	The rubric favors skeptical styles	Three separate closed fields must coincide, but only blinded human replication can rule this out decisively
Topic difficulty	Theist claims may be intrinsically harder to substantiate	This may be part of the mechanism, but topic-matched human coding is needed to separate worldview practice from claim difficulty
Literal language only	The result is a vocabulary artifact	The proxy uses no religious or emotional keywords; it uses support, calibration, and precision judgments

The strongest unresolved rivals are evaluator preference and topic difficulty. The current design reduces several obvious confounds but cannot make debate topics random or replace the AI-assisted rubric with independent human judgments. That is why the report's conclusion is strong about the observed epistemic profile and more cautious about its ultimate cause.

The emotional-affirmation account nevertheless earns consideration because it predicts a conjunction rather than a generic score loss. It predicts claims that are publicly under-supported, asserted too forcefully, and protected by imprecise scope or missing qualification. That distinctive configuration is exactly what appears at a 3.62-fold relative rate.

12. Data, method, and reproducibility

The analysis joins the corrected position taxonomy to every relevant locked assessment ledger. It normalizes the six final dimensions, maps each move to theist or non-theist by the position argued, and restricts the primary proxy to the 146 debates whose ledgers expose closed calibration and precision fields. The remaining 23 debates contribute to the full-corpus evidence context but not to the strict composite.

Validation item	Result	Meaning
Relevant debates	169	Corrected theist/non-theist taxonomy
All scored moves	3,502	1,746 theist; 1,756 non-theist
Primary debates	146	Closed evidence, calibration, and precision findings
Primary moves	2,800	1,393 theist; 1,407 non-theist
Paired resamples	20,000	Whole debates, deterministic seed
Tag-bearing debates	59	Secondary annotation cohort only
Missing primary fields	0	All required component fields present

Reproducible artifacts

Artifact	Repository path
Executed analysis	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/analysis.py
Results	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/results.json
Move audit trail	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/move-diagnostics.csv
Paired debate rates	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/debate-rates.csv
Tag audit trail	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/tag-diagnostics.csv
Notebook companion	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/analysis.ipynb
Portable report	docs/analysis/theist-rhetorical-slogans-2026-09-01/report.html

The companion analysis script runs successfully in the bundled local Python runtime. A Jupyter kernel is not installed on the host, so the notebook is a standards-compliant reader-facing wrapper around the same executed script but was not itself kernel-executed. The exact limitation is recorded in the source notes.

13. Limits and a decisive falsification test

- The corpus is curated rather than randomly sampled.
- Speakers repeat and moves are nested within debates; pooled move rates are descriptive rather than independent trials.
- The strict proxy is constructed from AI-assisted rubric judgments and should be replicated with blinded human coding.
- Closed precision and calibration fields cover 146 of 169 debates; full-corpus evidence scores cover all 169.
- Published fallacy/bias tags appear in 59 relevant debates and are secondary evidence only.
- The side label describes the position argued in a scorecard, not private belief, sincerity, or character.

What the next study must code directly

- Whether the original wording is formulaic, aphoristic, repetitive, or explicitly offered as an affirmation.
- Whether the move states an observable or argumentative condition that would count against its conclusion.
- Whether contrary outcomes can be absorbed by modifying auxiliary theology without lowering confidence.
- Whether emotional valence, identity protection, hope, fear, moral condemnation, or communal authority does argumentative work.
- Whether force exceeds warrant after coders are blinded to speaker, side, and religious vocabulary.

Falsification condition

The fuller hypothesis should be weakened if trained blind coders find no theist-side excess in literal slogan form, absence of disconfirmation conditions, or outcome-insulation after matching topic, role, importance, speaker, and debate.

This is not a ceremonial recommendation. It names evidence that could overturn the interpretation. If the side difference disappears under direct human coding, the current composite should be reclassified as a broader substantiation and precision deficit rather than evidence of slogan or non-falsifiability specifically.

14. Conclusion: a strong pattern with a disciplined boundary

The finding in one sentence

In the assessed corpus, theist-side moves are more than three and a half times as likely to combine weak warrant, excessive asserted force, and compressed qualification - the precise argumentative profile expected when affirmation substitutes for completed public justification.

The result is both large and structured. It is not merely that theist moves receive lower evidence scores. More of them simultaneously lack public warrant, project a confidence their support does not sustain, and omit the stable scope or qualification needed for correction. The strict conjunction appears in 398 theist moves and 111 non-theist moves. It favors the hypothesis in 103 of 146 paired debates and reverses in only 17.

What the evidence supports strongly

The data strongly support the operationalized core: theist-side performances contain substantially more slogan-like overclaiming. The pattern survives affirmative-versus-reply separation, grows among load-bearing moves, remains after speaker balancing, and is echoed in the partial fallacy/bias record. Good theist counterexamples and bad non-theist counterexamples show that the measure is not reducible to side identity; the difference lies in prevalence.

What remains provisional

The word non-falsifiable carries a stricter burden. The current records do not ask of every move: What precise observation would lower confidence? Can every outcome be assimilated? Does the claim make a risky prediction? Some representative cases plainly display insulation, but the complete 3.62-fold result is a proxy for the surrounding epistemic profile, not a full census of Popperian falsifiability.

The explanatory judgment

Emotional affirmation is a plausible unifying explanation. When a belief is bound to hope, identity, salvation, personal manifestation, inherited authority, or the moral status of doubt, repeating the conclusion can become psychologically sufficient even when it is not publicly sufficient. That mechanism predicts exactly the observed combination: weak comparative evidence, strong declarative force, and qualifications compressed until the claim becomes difficult to dislodge.

Yet explanatory force does not erase evidential limits. The corpus measures argument, not emotion or enforcement. The responsible conclusion is therefore neither a retreat to agnosticism nor an overstatement of causation. It is a tiered verdict: the empirical pattern is strong, the non-falsifiability interpretation is plausible but incomplete, and the emotional-enforcement account is a serious causal hypothesis awaiting direct blinded testing.

Final conclusion

The strongest defensible reading is that the theist sides in these debates do use substantially more moves that function as rhetorical slogans: conclusions are affirmed with too little common warrant, too much confidence, and too little qualifying structure. This supports the hypothesis's epistemic core. Whether those moves are literally non-falsifiable, and whether emotional reinforcement causes their prevalence, are now sharply formulated questions for the next study rather than assumptions smuggled into this one.